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The Recreation and Wellness Center

The Gym I Already Knew

Commercial gyms are close to identical and that is the point of them. Cardio machines sit near the door, where a beginner finds them first. Weight machines fill the middle. Free weights and squat racks go in the back. I have trained in that layout for years and I have a squat rack in my garage, so I already know how everything works.

The UCF Recreation and Wellness Center follows that template almost exactly. Entering from the upper level, the cardio machines are directly in front of the doors. Two food stands share that floor, selling smoothies and sandwiches. Off to the side is a turf area with medicine balls, resistance bands, and pull-up bars. Down the stairs is everything else: the weight machines, the basketball and racket courts, the lap pool, the rock-climbing wall, and at the very back, the free weights and squat racks. The building is dense with equipment and almost empty of decoration. Walking lanes stay clear. Where the walls are not glass, they are mirror.

I go in the early morning, and in the early morning the RWC is quiet. The sounds are mechanical: treadmill belts, a plate being set down, a short exchange between two people. The quiet tells me the morning crowd came to finish a task and leave. That is what I came to do too.



Figure 1: The RWC from outside in early morning light. The low sun and the empty approach show the hour I normally train, before the building fills.

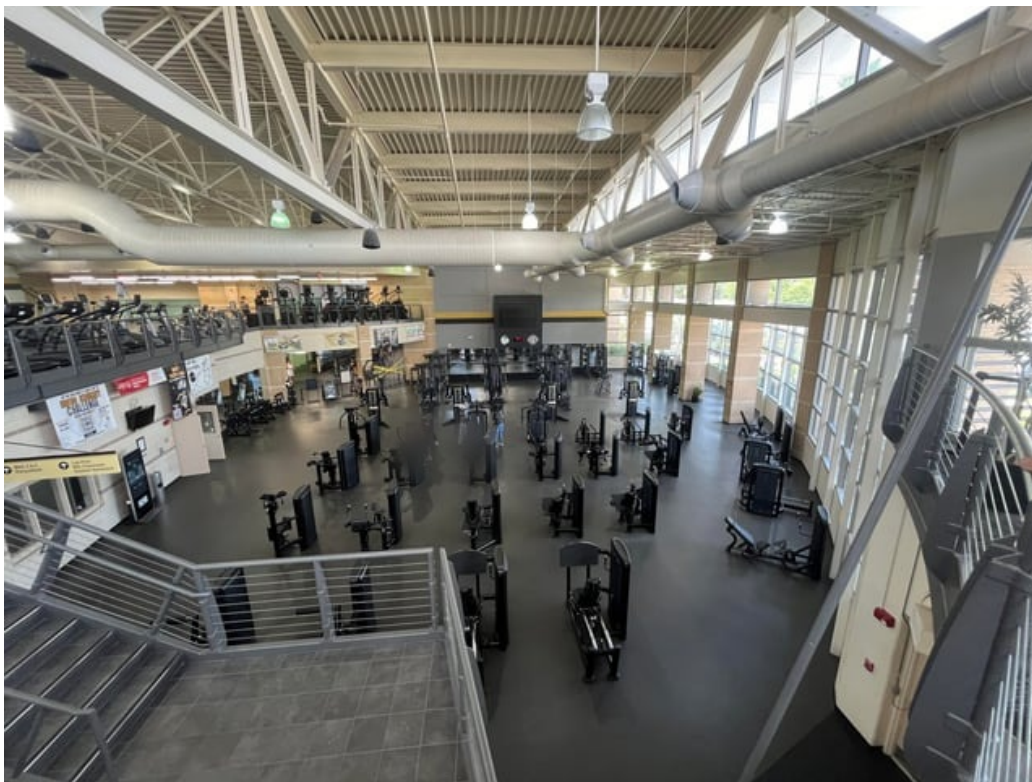


Figure 2: The interior follows the standard commercial gym layout. Photo by u/Jswee1, r/ucf; see Image Credits.

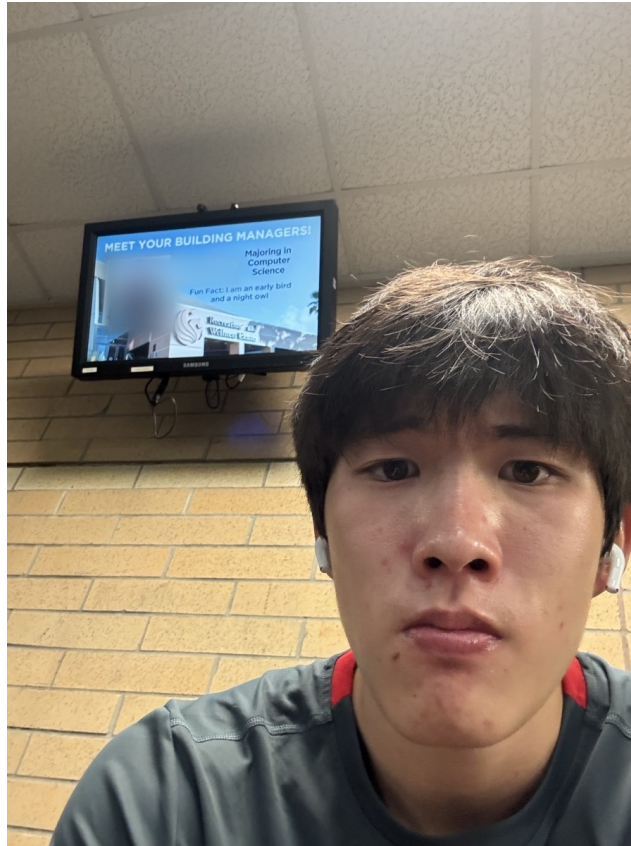


Figure 3: Me on the upper level before a morning session, AirPods already in. The screen behind me introduces the student building managers; that staff member's photo and name are blurred.

The Rhetorical Ecology of the RWC

Doug Downs argues that a rhetorical situation is better understood as an ecology, which he describes as “a network of myriad interconnecting and almost inseparable elements” (466). The useful word there is inseparable. The mirrors motivate me because they sit beside free weights that echo my garage, in the quiet of a morning, under natural light. Change one element and the meaning changes, even though nothing physical has moved.

There are a lot of rhetors here, and most of them never say anything. UCF administration commissioned the building and set its policies. Architects designed the two-level split, the glass exterior, and the decision to put the least intimidating equipment in the sightline of the door.

Staff and student workers author the space every day by enforcing rules and posting signage. Equipment manufacturers are rhetors too, since their weight stacks carry printed numbers that convert effort into a readable score. So are the users: every person who re-racks a plate or leaves one on the machine is telling the next person what the norms actually are. Downs argues that objects and machines act on an ecology the same way people do (466). The mirrors point you at yourself, the windows point you outside, and the missing tables tell you not to settle in.

The audience splits into groups that barely overlap: students who lift, students who swim or use the courts and the climbing wall, students passing through for food, and the student workers who enforce rules they also live under. The exterior is glass, so there is an outside audience too, and knowing people can see in changes how it feels to be inside.

Exigence, in Downs's terms, is the need that makes a rhetorical situation happen at all, and he points out that one ecology can answer several needs at once (467). The RWC answers more than one. A university with tens of thousands of students, many without access to a private gym, has to provide somewhere for them to be physically active. Academic stress needs to be release, because student health affects whether students stay enrolled. A large campus needs shared physical space where students meet outside of class. And a modern glass recreation center gets shown to prospective students, so the building is partly an argument aimed at people who do not attend UCF yet. None of those needs belongs to one person, they belong to the university.

A Room That Argues Without Words

Downs makes a point that matters more in a gym than almost anywhere else. He argues that rhetoric is physical and not only mental, so studying it means paying attention to what bodies and objects are doing, not just what people say (463). He also points out that most of what

people communicate to each other never gets spoken (461). The RWC runs on exactly that. There is very little writing on the walls and a lot of information in the room.

Glass and mirror do most of the work. Large windows admit a great deal of natural light and give a view outward, which I use between sets instead of looking at my phone. Mirrors cover most of the interior wall surface. They are sold as a tool for checking form, but I use them differently. They do what Downs calls presence, which is turning an abstract idea into something a person can see and react to right now (469). Progress over years is an abstraction. A mirror turns it into something I can see right now.

The weight stack does the same thing with numbers. Downs argues that people understand the world through stories, and that story structure turns up even in places that look like pure information (468). A cable stack is a narrative device. The pin sits in a printed number, and that number can be compared to the number it sat in last year or month. Moving the pin one plate lower tells the whole story in one number.



Figure 4: The printed numbers on a cable stack turn training into a readable record. Moving the pin one place lower than last year is the building telling me, in its own vocabulary, that I have changed.

Nothing about the color reads as UCF to me. The surfaces are the neutral grays and blacks of standard gym equipment. The one exception is a single wall in the free weight area, where a gold stripe and a black stripe run across gray cinderblock. There is no logo and no lettering, just two bands of paint at eye level. That is the whole of the school's visual claim on a two-level building, and it is a small one. The commercial gym template wins, and the RWC reads as a gym first and a UCF building second.



Figure 5: The only UCF color in the room: a gold stripe and a black stripe on gray cinderblock, with no logo and no lettering. Everything below it is standard gym equipment in standard gym colors.

That cuts both ways for me. Because the building does not insist that I am a student, it lets me arrive simply as a person who lifts. I belong here about as much as I would belong at any commercial gym.

The Mythos of the Floor

Downs separates mythos from values. Mythos is what an entire community takes for granted underneath everything else it believes. Values sit closer to the surface, and fewer people share any one of them (471–472). A gym has both, and the RWC makes almost no effort to state either one out loud. What signage exists is short and functional: wipe your machine down, put your weights back, a health poster or two. Because the walls are either window or mirror, there is

very little room for messaging, and what survived is what the staff decided they could not leave unsaid.

Those few signs are the written part of a much larger unwritten mythos. Re-rack your weights. Do not sit on a machine you are not using. Effort over time produces a result. Everything else gets enforced by other people's behavior, which is Downs's point that the users are rhetors too.

Values, being narrower, are where the RWC splits into different rooms at different hours. The early morning crowd wants efficiency and privacy. People arrive, work, and leave. The late morning crowd, especially on Tuesdays, treats the gym as a social event, and the volume in the building goes up. The equipment is the same.

Huy

The RWC holds every experience level at once. Beginners, longtime lifters, and older members all use the same floor, and nobody gets sorted into a section by how much they know. That range does not turn into a hierarchy. People are consistently friendly, and asking a stranger to work in is normal

Recently I was on the dip machine when another Asian student came over to me. We exchanged names. His name is Huy, he is from Vietnam, and he is studying electrical engineering. I am an electrical engineering major, so the conversation moved past small talk immediately. I asked him whether the courses were hard. We talked through my whole time at that machine. When I finished, I asked for his number. My thought walking out was that he would make a good mentor because he is doing the same degree.

Downs describes identification as what happens when one person gets another to line up with them, so that both read the situation the same way (475). He ties credibility to ethos, which

Aristotle measured by how much someone knows, how honest they seem, and whether they appear to want good things for you (475). Both were working in that conversation, and almost none of it was verbal at first. Huy and I identified with each other before either of us said anything about engineering. We were both Asian, in the same part of the building, doing the same kind of exercise. Downs's argument about unspoken communication (461) is the clearest explanation I have for why walking up to a stranger there felt normal.

The ethos arrived second and made the connection worth keeping. Once he said electrical engineering, he had standing with me that no amount of gym conversation would have produced. The building was designed to let people train. It also got me a contact with someone in the same major.

Kairos and the 10:45 Tuesday

One hour a week I cannot train early, and on Tuesdays I walk in around 10:45 in the morning. By that hour the building is a different place. It is packed and loud, with constant movement between stations and conversation layered over the equipment noise. I know before I reach the door that I am not going to enjoy it.

Downs uses the Greek word *kairos* for timing that nobody in the situation controls, and for the way that timing changes what a person can reasonably do (467). My Tuesday is *kairos*. This week I went in for chest, back, and shoulders. After my first exercise the plan stopped working, because the next machine I needed was occupied, and so was the one after that. I spent the session walking the floor looking for whatever was open and changing my workout around other people's.

I run on a schedule, so improvising annoys me. I did two exercises per muscle group instead of three, and I left earlier than I normally would, because I did not want to keep waiting.

Nothing about the building had changed since the morning before. Same racks, same mirrors, same signs. The only thing that changed was how many people were in it.

A Building That Does Not Want Me to Stay

The biggest limit on my belonging has nothing to do with people. There are no tables and no chairs anywhere on the workout floor, so sitting down with a laptop or a textbook is not physically possible. Student workers also enforce a rule that no bags or loose items may be on the floor during a workout; everything goes into a locker first.

Downs argues that every rhetorical act has some motive pushing it (464), and the motives behind these two choices are not hard to reconstruct. The locker rule is about safety and liability, since loose bags on a weight floor are both a tripping hazard and a theft risk. The missing furniture keeps people moving. With nowhere to sit, nobody settles in, and machines free up faster. The wipe-down signs are about hygiene in a high-traffic shared space, and the re-racking signs are about equipment life and injury prevention. Every one of those signs is reasonable.

The effect on me is still that my belonging here is clear. I belong in the RWC exactly as long as I am training. The moment I want to sit, read, or work, the building has nowhere to put me. The locker rule adds a smaller version of the same message: I have to surrender my belongings before I can participate, which makes the floor feel controlled.



Figure 6: The full lower floor. Every object in the room is a machine, a bench, or a rack. There is no table, no chair, and nowhere to sit that is not equipment, which is where my belonging stops. Photo by u/Jsweel, r/ucf; see Image Credits.

I should also name the part of this ecology I shut out myself. I train with both AirPods in, so the building's sound, its conversations, and much of its social energy never reach me. An ecology works on us through many channels at once, so cutting one off means giving up some of what the space offers. Most days that is the trade I want.

Making Meaning

Reading the RWC as an ecology explains something I had felt for years without having words for. The building has been arranged to produce a particular kind of person doing a specific kind of work, and it does almost all of that without writing anything down.

Downs's framework also explains why absence can be rhetorical. No sign tells me how long I can stay, but the missing tables make that argument anyway. In an ecology the gaps carry meaning the same way the objects do.

My sense of belonging in the RWC was never produced by the RWC alone. It came from the building, from other lifters, from the equipment manufacturers, from the squat rack in my garage at home, and from the hour I happen to arrive. Downs argues that elements like these cannot really be pulled apart.

Image Credits

All photographs are my own except Figures 2 and 6, which are the same image, credited below.

Jswheel [u/Jswheel]. "New gym equipment opens Monday." *Reddit*, r/ucf, Mar. 2024,

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Works Cited

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